I was integrated into senior dressing rooms from the age of fifteen, when I was taken under the wing of Ian Elliot and Robbie Barber, who opened the batting for Maldon. The average age of the team was late twenties; I sat there, listening almost in awe to their piss-taking and their unlikely shagging stories. The cricket was extremely competitive and they were brilliant, sharp-witted sledgers.

I'd barely gone through puberty and was small, so I was an obvious target, especially for the overseas pros we would come up against in the East Anglian Premier League. They were generally good cricketers, mostly South African or Australian, but their insults weren't terribly inventive. 'What the fuck are you doing here?' they'd ask. 'I'm going to kill you.'

I wasn't intimidated by the verbals and could handle the short stuff when it inevitably arrived. By the time I was eighteen I was able to dominate the opposition at club level. Typically, I wanted to end one game, at Mildenhall in Suffolk, early so that I could go out that evening with Alice, whom I had just met.

We were chasing 170, and I drove a South African bowler to distraction by tearing into him from the outset. Clearly peeved that a kid was showing him no respect, his default mechanism was to bowl shorter and shorter, and try to bounce me out. I scored 80-odd in no time, and the course of true love was smoothed.

It was a great learning experience. There was a brief trend for county academies to play in men's leagues. I didn't agree with the basic premise, that there would be continuity in the challenge. A promising player can become too insulated in youth cricket. There's a sense of dependence when support staff provide the throwdowns, and coaches are taking notes.

By playing for your club, rather than representing your county academy, you're dealing with the real world, playing teams of different ages from different backgrounds. You are playing alongside a forty-year-old with three kids who has no inclination to mollycoddle you. You organize throwdowns with your mates. You embrace the mentality of a clubman, share such rituals as the Thursday-night barbeque around the pavilion.

Playing for an academy doesn't mean you've made it. The county badge on your helmet gives you no privileges. It doesn't hurt to raise your head above the parapet. In some public schoolboys there's a distance, a slight sense of entitlement, that needs to get knocked out of them. I had the